

‘Now you are contradicting yourself, JC. Just a while ago you said you never allowed ego to interfere with your trading decisions. By hammering some stock just because you want to screw a rival, you risk losing money,’ I pointed out.

He smiled. ‘That is okay. In my position, I can afford an enemy or two. There are plenty of other stocks where you can make money.’

But JC did end up making more than just one or two enemies. According to the market grapevine, he had managed to infuriate the promoters of quite a few companies by hammering their stocks. One of them happened to be a Mumbai-based real estate company with politically well-connected promoters. The promoters first asked him to back off from their stock. JC in turn asked them to get lost. Infuriated by his gall, the promoters sent goons to his office to intimidate him. I even heard that he was roughed up so that he got the message loud and clear. To ask JC about that would be testing his patience. But I know that for some time JC was moving around with a couple of bodyguards in tow. Those who did not know the reason felt it was yet another of his antics to exaggerate his importance.

We chatted for over an hour. As I was leaving, JC came up to my car to see me off. ‘You come across as an intelligent fellow to me. I think we should do business together,’ he said.

I told him it was a good idea, but though we exchanged market views quite a few times after that, we never got down to doing business together.